

BUSN 198R: Carmel Dill-Cruz Internship Reflection

1. Provide a brief overview of the internship, the number of hours worked, and what you did.

This summer, I had the opportunity to intern at Bonduelle Americas, a global salad manufacturing company, where I worked as their Environmental, Social, and Governance (ESG) intern. This internship was 10 weeks long, full-time, allotting to about 400 work hours this summer. This internship allowed me to gain firsthand insight into what sustainability looks like in the corporate world. As an ESG intern, I spent the summer developing an action plan to increase plant-rich awareness for Bonduelle Associates, supporting the company's mission "to inspire the transition toward a plant-rich diet to contribute to people's well-being and planet health". Beyond that, I gain exposure to a wide range of corporate sustainability practices, ranging from water and energy consumption, the science behind eco-conscious packaging and carbon emission reduction strategies. I also assisted in researching climate risks and analyzing how they could impact Bonduelle both operationally and financially.

2. What were some of the *new things* that you learned during the internship?

Carbon Emissions: In the corporate world, the way that businesses track their carbon emissions is by classifying them into 3 scopes:

- Scope 1: Direct emissions from owned or controlled sources (e.g., fleet fuel, natural gases, refrigerant leaks).
- Scope 2: Indirect emissions from the generation of their purchased electricity.

- Scope 3: Indirect emissions not included in scope 2 that occur across the value chain (cultivated produce, ingredients, packaging, industry, travel, supply chain, and consumer).

In my major (Environmental Studies), we always talk about the different ways organizations *produce* large quantities of carbon emissions. However, in this internship, I learned the specific strategies businesses use to identify and mitigate their emissions depending on where they are in the value chain. So I went from learning how they get produced → how to reduce their carbon footprint depending on the specific practice.

B-Corp Certification: Bonduelle Americas is a B-Corp certified organization, which means a lot to me as an eco-conscious consumer. A B-Corp certified company is an organization that meets high standards of social and environmental performance, accountability, and transparency, and is legally committed to prioritizing stakeholders, not just shareholders, in its corporate governance. This certification demonstrates a company's positive impact on its workers, communities, customers, and the environment by making profit and purpose equally important.

This summer, I assisted in Bonduelle Americas ' recertification for B-Corp, as they need to go through recertification every 4 years. Having always admired what B-Corp stands for, being able to see how specifically B-Corp grades organizations on their practices and what kind of data companies need to provide in order to prove their compliance was eye-opening. B-Corp truly takes its meaning seriously, and as a consumer, seeing a label actually mean more than a "label" was really good to see.

3. What were some things that surprised you?

One thing that surprised me is how many gallons of water companies use. For some reason, it never occurred to me that companies used *millions of gallons a week*. This coming fall, I will be taking my first water resources class, where I will be learning about water conservation for the first time. However, sitting in on Environmental Management System meetings and just going over how much water the company used was eye-opening for me. The second thing for me was how difficult company communication can be. I am unsure if this was just my own experience or if it is common in the corporate world, but it took a long time to hear back from other associates to respond to my emails, if at all.

4. How will you use the learnings from this internship to position yourself for a job interview? Ex: What have you learned to do well due to your experience?

In my future interviews, I plan to position myself as someone who brings both a scientific foundation in environmental studies and the ability to translate that knowledge into business strategy. Before this internship, I primarily understood climate change through a research and technical lens, using tools like GIS, R-Studio, and scientific analysis to study climate risks. Through my ESG internship at Bonduelle, I developed the ability to apply these learnings directly to real-world business operations and risks. For example, I analyzed how increasing heat waves in Georgia put stress on aging power grids, leading to more frequent blackouts. In a food manufacturing context, this means halted production, product spoilage when refrigeration fails, and ultimately financial losses. From this, I learned how to connect scientific climate data to tangible business risks to start developing solutions that are both sustainable and practical. What I've learned to do well is bridge the gap between science and business: identifying where climate

risks intersect with operational challenges, and then framing them in a way that companies can act on. This positions me as someone who not only understands the data but can also help organizations make smarter, sustainability-driven decisions.

5. Are there any specific infights or observations related to the EMPAC model that you learned during your internship?

One way I was able to observe the EMPAC model being used was how Bonduelle can position itself in the market by emphasizing its B-Corp Certification. Being a company that produces salad bowls, there is already a lot of competition in that specific market. However, the advantage that Bondulle has is that a lot of its competitors are not B-Corp certified. By promoting that certification, they can differentiate themselves as one of the only salad bowl brands committed to sustainability, ethics, and social responsibilities, values that some consumers may be seeking out more. This is also used to help justify the prices.